Reminiscence Across Generations for Females

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Introduction

Family interactions around the dinner table about day-to-day and past experiences emerge once every five minutes (Bohanek, et al., 2009). These social interactions play a role in cognitive development and are a source of autobiographical memory during preschool years (Nelson & Fivush, 2004).

This study furthers previous research that demonstrated the benefits of reminiscence within families. Previous research has found women tend to be more elaborative and they are able to recall memories from an earlier age (Reese & Fivush, 1996). By looking at similarities within and differences across families, the question arises: Are women's elaborative styles varied or consistent across generations?

This study is important because connections have been found between mothers' elaborative style and their child's ability to recall more information, develop better strategic memory, language, literacy skills, understanding of self and others, and better attachment relationships (Nelson & Fivush, 2004; Fivush, Hayden & Reese, 2006).

Literature Review

❖ **Reminiscence differences between mothers and fathers**
- Mothers are elaborative and evaluate their daughter's memories more than their son's. Fathers reminiscence is repetitive, and less elaborative. Fathers evaluate their son's memories more than their daughter's (Reese & Fivush, 1996).
- Mothers tend to elaborate more about specific emotions (Fivush, Brotman, Buckner & Goodman, 2000).
- Mother and fathers contributions to reminiscing significantly impact internalizing and externalizing behaviors among children (Bohanek, Fivush, Zaman, Lepore, Merchant & Duke, 2009).

❖ **Reminiscence among mothers and children**
- Children's elaborative patterns are similar to their mothers (Fivush & Vasudeva, 2002).
- Mothers attachment to their child is connected to how elaborative they reminisce (Fivush & Vasudeva,, 2002).

❖ **Reminiscence between generations**
- Older generations reminisce more often (Merriam, 1993).
- When reminiscing with grandchildren, grandparents focus on learning activities, unexpected events, storytelling, sharing experiences and cultural exchanges (Forghani & Neustaedter, 2014).
- Grandchildren show interest in storytelling with grandparents, especially when the story is about the child's parent when they were young (Forghani & Neustaedter, 2014).

❖ **Autobiographical Memory**
- Autobiographical memory allows individuals to add their perspective and interpretation, and allows for an evaluation of *self*, *other*, and *time*, thus creating their own personal history (Fivush, 2010). Once a child has developed a sophisticated autobiographical memory the child understands that others are different from them



Methodology

This study used methods based loosely on previous work, specifically the mother-child interviews conducted by Reese, Hayden & Fivush (1993).

❖ **Participants**

Participants will consist of girls between the age of four and six, their mothers and their grandmothers. Participants will randomly be chosen from a list of volunteers provided by the Institute of Child Development at the University of Minnesota.

❖ **Instructions**

The family of three are split into three sets of dyads, grandmother-mother, grandmother-grandchild, mother-child. Before each dyad sits down to talk about past events, the mother or grandmother of the dyad is requested that she choose two past events to talk about that spanned no more than 1 day and were one time occurrences the child had experienced neither before nor since. The women were asked to avoid talking about events that were extended in time (e.g., family vacations, the Christmas holidays) or routine (e.g., birthday parties). These events are not shared with the child until the dyad is sitting in the interview room with a recorder recording the conversations.

❖ **Adult-child conversation**

After events are selected, the adult and child sit together with an audio-recorder to record the conversation and the researcher leaves the room. In this conversation there are no time restrictions.

❖ **Adult-adult conversation**

The procedure for the grandmother-mother conversation is similar. The grandmother is asked to select 2 events to discuss. One event that occurred within the past year and the second occurred when her daughter was the age of the grand-daughter.



Expected Results

❖ We expect that daughters elaborative styles will be similar to their mothers. These similarities are expected to be seen when the mother is elaborating with her child. If the mother grew up in an environment that was highly elaborative and regularly reminisced, the mother would pass these characteristics on to her child when reminiscing.

❖ We expect that grandmothers who were more elaborative and often reminisced will pass these traits on when reminiscing with their grandchild, the daughter of her daughter. If a grandmother tended to be more elaborative while reminiscing, she will do the same type of reminiscing with the grandchild as she does with her own daughter.

Future Research

❖ This study was limited because it only used female English Speakers. This study did not focus on personal and social factors such as socio-economic status, ethnicity, education, religion, etc.

❖ Future studies should focus on personal and social factors that may influence the elaborative styles within families



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